Responsible Administrator: VP Student Affairs
Responsible Office: Dean of Students
Effective Date: 09/17/2019
Approved by: President
Date of Revision: 10/06/2025

Political Activity Guidelines

Policy Statement

Southeastern Louisiana University recognizes and upholds the rights of individuals and groups to engage in political activities as guaranteed by the First Amendment of the U.S. Constitution. As a public institution, Southeastern must also comply with applicable federal and state laws, as well as University of Louisiana System policies, to ensure that political activities do not interfere with the University's mission, operations, or tax-exempt status. The University must balance the rights of free expression with its responsibility to maintain order, manage vehicular and pedestrian traffic, and ensure that activities do not detract from University-sponsored events or the academic environment.

Political fundraising at University-sponsored events is strictly prohibited because such activity in support of or in opposition to a candidate, campaign, or political party risks jeopardizing the University's or its affiliated organizations' federal tax status under IRC §115 (for governmental entities) and IRC §501(c)(3) (for affiliated charitable entities). While the University does not restrict lawful political speech, Louisiana R.S. 18:1470 prohibits the erection, display, or posting of political campaign signs on publicly owned property or rights-of-way (with limited statutory exceptions). Accordingly, political advertising will not be sold or displayed for Athletics events or elsewhere on campus

Individuals and companies are also prohibited from using University events, including Athletics events and other campus-sponsored activities, as platforms to market, promote, or solicit support for a political candidate, party, issue, or campaign. Additionally, individuals and companies may not sell or distribute food, beverages, or other items to the general public in connection with any political activity or fundraising effort without written authorization from the University or the Athletic Department. These restrictions protect University operations, maintain event integrity, and ensure compliance with applicable laws and tax regulations

Louisiana Act 584 of 2024 further affirms Southeastern's commitment to protecting free expression while maintaining policies that prevent substantial disruption. The University must remain neutral in all political matters and avoid any appearance of endorsing a political candidate or issue. In accordance with La. R.S. 17:3399.39 (Act 584 of 2024), no University employee, instructor, or representative may require or impose, as a condition of enrollment, course credit, or grading, that a student participate in, or be penalized for choosing not to participate in, any political activity or event. Nothing in this policy shall be interpreted to limit or discourage a student's voluntary political expression or association.

Purpose of Policy

The purpose of this policy is to establish guidelines for political activities on Southeastern's campus, ensuring that such activities are conducted in a manner that respects free speech rights while maintaining University operations, protecting institutional neutrality, and ensuring compliance with applicable laws and regulations.

Applicability

These guidelines apply to all students, faculty, staff, visitors, contractors, and any individuals or groups engaging in political activities on Southeastern's property. Political activity includes, but is not limited to, political speech, political fundraising, political signage, campaign-related materials, and the distribution of political literature.

Policy Procedure

Southeastern Louisiana University upholds the rights of individuals to engage in political activity while ensuring that such activities do not disrupt University operations, events, or the academic environment. Individuals and organizations must adhere to University policies governing public speech, assembly, signage, solicitation, and distribution of materials on campus.

The non-commercial distribution of political literature by individuals in traditional public forums such as outdoor sidewalks and open lawns is permitted without prior approval, provided the activity is peaceful, does not obstruct pedestrian or vehicular traffic, and does not disrupt University operations or scheduled events. Political signage may not be posted without prior approval as outlined in the *Public Speech, Assembly, and Demonstrations Policy* and the *Sign, Flyer, and Policy*. Additionally, sales and solicitation activities require approval and must comply with the *Soliciting on Campus Policy***.** However, political fundraising and political advertising remain strictly prohibited as outlined in this policy.

For specific guidelines and approval processes, individuals should refer to the applicable policies.

Enforcement of Policy

Individuals or groups engaging in unauthorized political activities will be required to cease their activity immediately and may face removal from University property, loss of privileges, and appropriate disciplinary action. Student violators will be referred to the Office of Student Advocacy and Accountability for potential disciplinary action. Faculty, staff, contractors, or visitors who violate this policy may be reported to the relevant University department or office for appropriate action, including removal from the campus or event.

Employees are further reminded that Louisiana Ethics Law, La. R.S. 42:1111–1121, prohibits the use of public office, University property, or state resources for political campaigning or personal gain. Violations of these provisions will result in penalties under state law in addition to University disciplinary action.

[End of Policy]